

The Virtual COMBAT

The BJP's prime ministerial candidate takes a lead in cyberspace as parties log on in a bid to woo the youth

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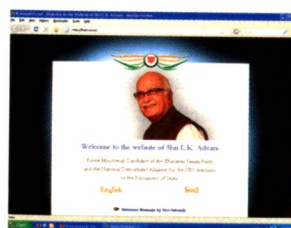
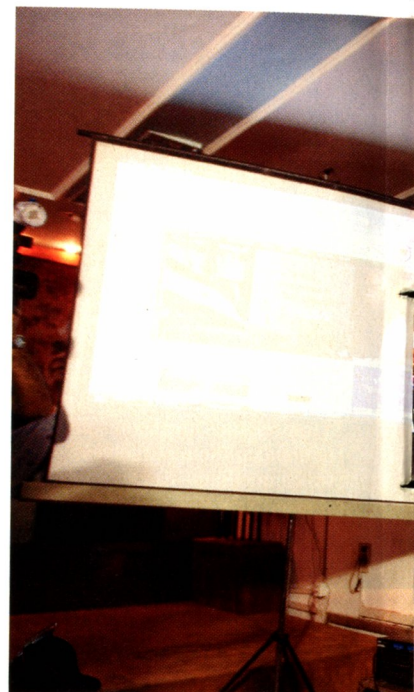
The fine art of political campaign has just got itself a new portal. E-2009 will not just be fought at the grassroots or in television studios but also in cyberspace as most political leaders acquire a virtual persona. Look at the BJP. It may have failed in keeping its allies together, but the party's prime minister-in-waiting L.K. Advani has surely created a buzz in cyberspace. Almost any search on Google leads the netizen to a link to his website. The sheer omnipresence of the link to www.lkadvani.in has made people sit up and take note. Even websites of Pakistani newspapers are not free of the looming Advani image, while football aficionados in India checking out the latest scores of the UEFA Champions League are likely to run into pictures not of a bald Wayne Rooney but a shorn Advani.

The cyber fetish is spreading. Parties like the Congress and SP are now in talks with Google to aid them in digital advertising—a concept being used for the first time as a campaign tool. The BJP, at least in this area, has stolen a march over others. As of now, Congress President Sonia Gandhi or the party's youth icon Rahul Gandhi do not even have an official personal website. They both have unofficial websites being run by some party supporters from Kerala.

The Congress has two websites; one is official which gives out the press

briefings and the other is dedicated to the Gandhi family and is managed by Rahul's backroom boys. It goes by the unassuming title www.pressbrief.in as its essential purpose is to enlighten the media about its not-so-accessible leadership and give detailed information of every public move made by the first family. It is now planning a revamp of its site, though Vishwa-jeet Prithvijit Singh, the Congress' top spin doctor, says that this is not a reaction to the Advani site but aimed at giving the party a "cleaner, sharper look". There are no blogs because, says Singh, the Congress does not believe in putting up blogs written by an editorial board, and not the leader.

Meanwhile, Advani's team has carefully worked on crafting the website, making it the largest political website. The team has also been systematically working towards popularising the website ever since it was launched on November 8, 2008, his birthday. From 300 visitors a day, around 25,000 people visit the website daily, which translates into nearly



lkadvani.in
30,00,000
page views per month



aicc.org.in
27,000
page views per month

a lakh page views. "It is like an online political rally. With the vast reach of the Internet, I don't see why we cannot have one lakh visitors on the site," says Prodyut Bora, national convener of BJP's Information Technology Cell.

In a country where two-thirds of the population is below 35 years of age, both the BJP and Congress are focusing on the youth vote. According to Advani's managers, there are as many as 100 million first-time voters out there and it is to woo them that he